

The Twelve Olympians: Zeus, Hera, and Their Children



First, then, we should define what kind of friendship we are looking for. For there is, some think, a friendship towards God and towards inanimate things, but they are wrong. We believe that friendship exists where there is a reciprocity of friendly affection, but friendship towards God does not admit of such reciprocity, not even of a one-sided friendship on our part. For it would be absurd if someone were to say that he had a friendly love towards Zeus.

—ARISTOTLE, *Magna Moralia* 1208 b25–30

THUS ZEUS IS ESTABLISHED as lord of gods and men. He is supreme, but he does share his powers with his brothers. Zeus himself assumes the sky as his special sphere; Poseidon, the sea; and Hades, the Underworld. Homer (*Iliad* 15. 187–192) says that they cast lots for their realms. Zeus takes his sister Hera as his wife; she reigns by his side as his queen and subordinate. His sisters Hestia and Demeter share in divine power and functions, as we shall see, and the other major gods and goddesses are also given significant prerogatives and authority as they are born.

And so a circle of major deities (fourteen in number) comes into being; their Greek and Roman names are as follows: Zeus (Jupiter), Hera (Juno), Poseidon (Neptune), Hades (Pluto), Hestia (Vesta), Hephaestus (Vulcan), Ares (Mars), Apollo, Artemis (Diana), Demeter (Ceres), Aphrodite (Venus), Athena (Minerva), Hermes (Mercury), and Dionysus (Bacchus).¹ This list was reduced to a canon of twelve Olympians by omitting Hades (whose specific realm is under the earth) and replacing Hestia with Dionysus, a great deity who comes relatively late to Olympus.

Hestia, Goddess of the Hearth and Its Fire

Although her mythology is meager, Hestia is important. She rejected the advances of both Poseidon and Apollo and vowed to remain a virgin; like Athena and Artemis, then, she is a goddess of chastity.² But she is primarily the goddess of the hearth and its sacred fire; her name, Hestia, is the Greek word for “hearth.” Among primitive peoples fire was obtained with difficulty, kept alive, and revered for its basic importance in daily needs and religious ceremony. The hearth, too, was the center first of the family and then of the larger political units: the tribe, the city, and the state. Transmission of the sacred fire from one settlement to another represented a continuing bond of affection and kinship. Thus, both the domestic and the communal hearth were designated as holy, and the goddess herself presided over them. Hestia often gained precedence at banquets and in sacrificial ritual; for as the first-born of Cronus and Rhea she was considered august, one of the older generation of the gods.

There are two *Homeric Hymns to Hestia*. Number 24 briefly calls on her as the personification of the protecting flame of the sacred hearth in a temple:

Hestia, you who tend the hallowed house of the far-shooter Apollo in holy Pytho, liquid oil always drips from your hair.³ Come to this house; enter in sympathetic support, along with Zeus, the wise counselor. Grant as well a pleasing grace to my song.

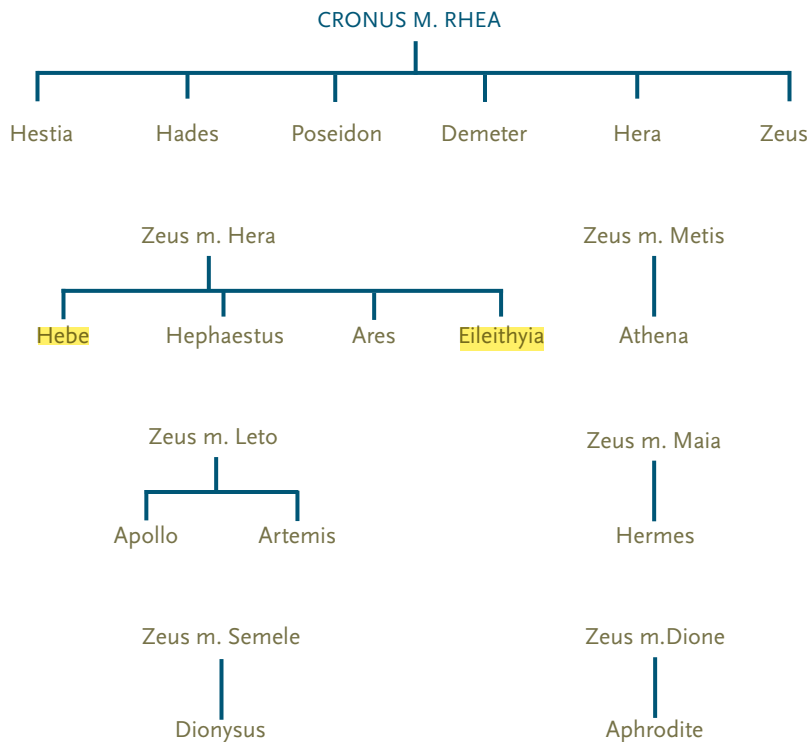


Figure 5.1. The Lineage of Major Deities

In number 29, Hestia is invoked as the protectress of the hearth in the home; the poet appeals to the god Hermes as well, since both deities protect the house and bring good fortune.

Hestia, you have as your due an everlasting place in the lofty homes of immortal gods and human beings who walk on earth—the highest of honors and a precious right. For without you, there are no banquets for mortals where one does not offer honey-sweet wine as a libation to Hestia, first and last.

And you, Hermes, the slayer of Argus, son of Zeus and Maia, messenger of the blessed gods, bearer of a golden staff and giver of good things, along with revered and beloved Hestia, be kind and help me. Come and inhabit beautiful homes, in loving harmony. For since you both know the splendid achievements of mortals on earth, follow in attendance with intelligence and beauty. 10

Hail, daughter of Cronus, you and Hermes, bearer of a golden staff; yet I shall remember you both and another song too.

The Diverse Character of Zeus

Zeus is a passionately amorous god; he mates with countless goddesses and mortal women, and his offspring are legion. Most genealogies demanded the glory and authority of the supreme god himself as their ultimate progenitor. Along with this necessity emerged the character of a Zeus conceived and readily developed by what might be called a popular mythology. This Zeus belonged to a monogamous society in which the male was dominant; however moral the basic outlook, the standards for the man were different from those for the woman. Illicit affairs were possible and even, if not officially sanctioned, were at least condoned for men, but under no circumstances tolerated for women. Thus Zeus is the glorified image not only of the husband and father, but also of the lover. The gamut of Zeus' conquests will provide a recurrent theme.

As the picture evolves, Zeus' behavior may be depicted as amoral or immoral or merely a joke—the supreme god can stand above conventional standards. At other times he will act in harmony with them, and more than once he must face the shrewish harangues of his wife, Hera, and pay at least indirectly through pain and suffering wrought by his promiscuity.

Yet this same Zeus (as we shall see later in his worship at Dodona and Olympia) becomes the one god, and his concerns envelop the whole sphere of morality for both gods and humankind. He is the wrathful god of justice and virtue, upholding all that is sacred and holy in the moral order of the universe. This Zeus we discuss at greater length in Chapter 6. In the literature, the portrayal of Zeus depends on both the period and the intent and purpose of individual authors. The conception of deity is multifaceted, infinitely varied, and wondrously complex.

We are already familiar with Zeus the god of the sky, the cloud-gatherer of epic. The etymological root of his name means "bright" (as does that of Jupiter). His attributes are thunder and lightning, and he is often depicted about to hurl them. The king of gods and men is a regal figure represented as a mature man

in his prime, usually bearded. He bears as well the aegis, a word meaning “goat skin” that originally designated merely the cloak of a shepherd. For Zeus it is a shield with wonderful and miraculous protective powers.⁴ The majestic eagle and mighty oak were sacred to Zeus.

Finally, it must be fully appreciated that the patriarchy of Zeus was by no means always absolute or supreme. Here are a few examples of his vulnerability. According to some, Zeus’ authority was not supreme but always subject to the dictates of fate or the feminine fates (see the final section of this chapter), and the powerful goddess of love, Aphrodite, proclaims in the *Homeric Hymn to Aphrodite* (5) (p. 201) that she is the greatest deity of all, for she can bend not only humans but even the gods (including almighty Zeus) to her amorous will. Only three goddesses, Athena, Artemis, and Hestia, defy her subjection. Demeter, the greatest matriarch of antiquity with her dominant and universal Eleusinian mysteries (see Chapter 14), refused to submit to the patriarchy of both Zeus and Hades in her grief and outrage over the rape of her daughter Persephone and won. A startling revolution against the power of Zeus is alluded to in the *Iliad* (1. 399–401): When Hera, Poseidon, and Athena bound Zeus in chains, it was Thetis, the mother of Achilles, who rescued the supreme god. The most determined critic who constantly challenged the authority of Zeus was his sister and wife Hera.

Zeus and Hera

The union of Zeus and Hera represents yet another enactment of the sacred marriage between the sky-god and earth-goddess; this is made clear in the lines from Homer (*Iliad* 14. 346–351) that describe their lovemaking:

The son of Cronus clasped his wife in his arms and under them the divine earth sprouted forth new grass, dewy clover, crocuses, and hyacinths, thick and soft, to protect them from the ground beneath. On this they lay together and drew around themselves a beautiful golden cloud from which the glistening drops fell away.

Hera has little mythology of her own, being important mainly as Zeus’ consort and queen; yet she has great power. The *Homeric Hymn to Hera* (12) makes this power very clear:

I sing about golden-throned Hera, whom Rhea bore, immortal queen, outstanding in beauty, sister and wife of loud-thundering Zeus; she is the illustrious one whom all the blessed ones throughout high Olympus hold in awe and honor, just as they do Zeus who delights in his lightning and thunder.

Hera consistently appears as the vehement wife and mother who will punish and avenge the sexual escapades of her husband; she consistently acts with a severity befitting her stature as mother, wife, and queen, the fierce champion of morality and marriage.⁵ Iris, the fleet-footed and winged goddess of the rainbow (see p. 172), at times a messenger of the gods, often is depicted as the particular servant of Hera. When Iris serves in this capacity, then Hermes performs his role as the messenger of Zeus alone. In art, Hera is depicted as regal

Zeus and Hera, limestone and marble metope from Temple E at Selinus, ca. 470 B.C. Selinus, on the southwestern coast of Sicily, contained many temples, eight of which have been identified, each given an alphabetical letter. Temple E was restored during the twentieth century. It is one of a group of three Doric temples, the exterior decoration of which included metopes. This one portrays the *hieros gamos* of Zeus and Hera. Zeus sits on Mt. Ida and draws Hera toward himself. Hera, whose arms and feet are made of white marble, stands facing Zeus with her veil drawn back to signify her status as his wife. She wears archaic clothing, while her dignified stance contrasts with the relaxed attitude of her husband. (Vanni/Art Resource, NY)



and matronly, often with attributes of royalty, such as a crown and a scepter. Homer describes her as ox-eyed and white-armed, both epithets presumably denoting her beauty. If we mistranslate “ox-eyed” as “doe-eyed,” perhaps the complimentary nature of that adjective becomes clear. The peacock is associated with Hera; this association is explained by her role in the story of Io (told in Chapter 4). Argos was a special center for her worship, and a great temple was erected there in her honor. Hera was worshiped less as an earth-goddess than as a goddess of women, marriage, and childbirth, functions she shares with other goddesses.

The Sanctuary of Zeus at Olympia

Olympia is a sanctuary beside the river Alpheus, in the territory of the Peloponnesian city of Elis. By the time of the reorganization of the Olympic Games in 776,⁶ Zeus had become the principal god of the sanctuary, and his son Heracles was said to have founded the original Olympic Games, one of the principal athletic festivals in the ancient world.⁷ An earlier cult of the hero Pelops and his wife, Hippodamia (see p. 437), continued, nevertheless, along with the worship of Zeus and Hera, whose temples were the principal buildings of the sanctuary at the peak of its greatness.

Centaurs and Lapiths

Ixion, the sinner who was eventually punished by being bound to a wheel in the realm of Hades, had impregnated the Cloud (the Greek word is *Nephele*), a deception placed by Zeus in the likeness of his wife, Hera (see p. 376).

This cloud (*Nephele*) gave birth to the monster **Centaurus**, which mated with the mares that grazed the slopes of Mt. Pelion and became the father of the Centaurs, creatures with a human head and torso and the legs and body of a horse. The most famous centaur was **Chiron**, who differs from the others in that he was wise and gentle, skilled in medicine and music. He taught Achilles, Jason, and Asclepius. Pindar calls him the son of Cronus and the nymph Philyra. The other centaurs are generally portrayed as violent beings, and their best-known legend is that of their fight with the Thessalian tribe of the Lapiths.

The Lapith chieftain **Pirithoüs** was the son of Ixion, and the centaurs were invited to his wedding. At the feast they got drunk and attempted to carry off the bride, Hippodamia, and the other Lapith women. The violent scene was frequently represented in Greek art, for example, in the west pediment of the temple of Zeus at Olympia described earlier and in the metopes of the Parthenon at Athens. The battle is described at length in the twelfth book of Ovid's *Metamorphoses*.

Another Lapith was **Caeneus**. Born a girl, **Caenis**, she was seduced by Poseidon, who then granted her anything she wanted. She asked to be turned into a man and to become invulnerable. As a man, Caeneus set up his spear and ordered people to worship it. This impiety led Zeus to bring about his death. During the battle at the wedding of Pirithoüs and Hippodamia he was attacked by the centaurs, who buried him under the enormous pile of tree trunks that they hurled at him. Either his body was driven down into the Underworld by their weight or else a yellow-winged bird emerged from the pile, which the seer Mopsus announced to be Caeneus transformed.



A Centaur and Centaress. These two sculptures come from the Roman villa of Oplontis, southeast of Naples, which was ruined in the eruption of Vesuvius in A.D. 79. They were half of a group of four that made up a fountain. The Centaur carries a boar upside down on his left shoulder; a thin pipe brings water to the fountain through the boar's mouth. His club, ferocious look, and the dead animal are in keeping with the traditional violence of Centaurs. (height 35.6 inches). The Centaress is shown as a musician; in her left hand was a lyre (of which part of the tortoise-shaped soundbox is visible) and in her right a *plectrum* with which to pluck the strings of the lyre. Her breasts are naked and over her shoulders is a goatskin. (height 36.4 inches). (Leisure and Luxury in the Age of Nero)

The temple of Hera was older, while the temple of Zeus was built in the fifth century with a monumental statue of Zeus placed inside.⁸ The statue and the sculptures on the temple itself together formed a program in which religion, mythology, and local pride were articulated on a scale paralleled only by the sculptures of the Parthenon at Athens.

On the west pediment was displayed the battle of the Greeks and the centaurs at the wedding of a son of Zeus, the Lapith king **Pirithoüs**, a myth that also



Hera. Roman copy of a Greek original from the second half of the 5th century B.C., perhaps by Alcamenes. Known as the Barberini Hera, the goddess carries a royal scepter and holds a patera (a shallow libation vessel) in her left hand. She wears a crown and a closely clinging chiton, which reveals her body underneath and is falling from her left side. The right arm, nose, and pieces of drapery are restorations. (Scala/Art Resource, NY/© Artres)

appears in the metopes of the Parthenon. The central figure in the pediment is another son of Zeus, Apollo, imposing order on the scene of violence and chaos (illustrated on p. 269).

The east pediment shows the scene before the fateful chariot race between **Pelops** and **Hippodamia** and her father Oenomaüs. Zeus himself is the central figure, guaranteeing the success of Pelops in the coming race and the winning of Hippodamia as his wife.

The Twelve Labors of Heracles were carved in the metopes of the Doric frieze (each about 1.6 meters in height), six above the entrance porch to the inner chamber (cella, or naos) at the east end of the temple, and six above the corresponding “false” porch on the west end. The climax of the Labors, above the east porch, was the local myth of the cleansing of the stables of Augeas, king of Elis (see p. 559). In this labor (and in three others) Athena is shown helping the hero, and in the labors of the Nemean Lion and Cerberus, Hermes is the helper.

The most complex union of myth and religion was in the statue of Zeus, carved by the Athenian sculptor **Pheidias** and the most admired of all ancient statues. It was huge (about 42 feet in height), and its surfaces were made of precious materials, gold (for the clothing and ornaments), and ivory (for the flesh). It inspired awe in those who saw it. Although nothing remains of the statue today, we can reconstruct its appearance.⁹ Zeus was seated on his throne, carrying a figure of Nike (Victory) in his right hand, and in his left hand a scepter, on which perched his eagle. On the feet of the throne were depicted the myths of the Theban sphinx and the killing of the children of Niobe by Apollo and Artemis. Also part of the structure of the throne was a representation of Heracles fighting the Amazons, and Heracles appeared again in the paintings on a screen that enclosed the underpart of the throne, performing two of his labors (the Apples of the Hesperides and the Nemean Lion), as well as freeing Prometheus. In the carved reliefs on the base of the throne, the Olympian gods accompanied the miraculous birth of Aphrodite from the sea. In front of the statue was a reflecting pool of olive oil.

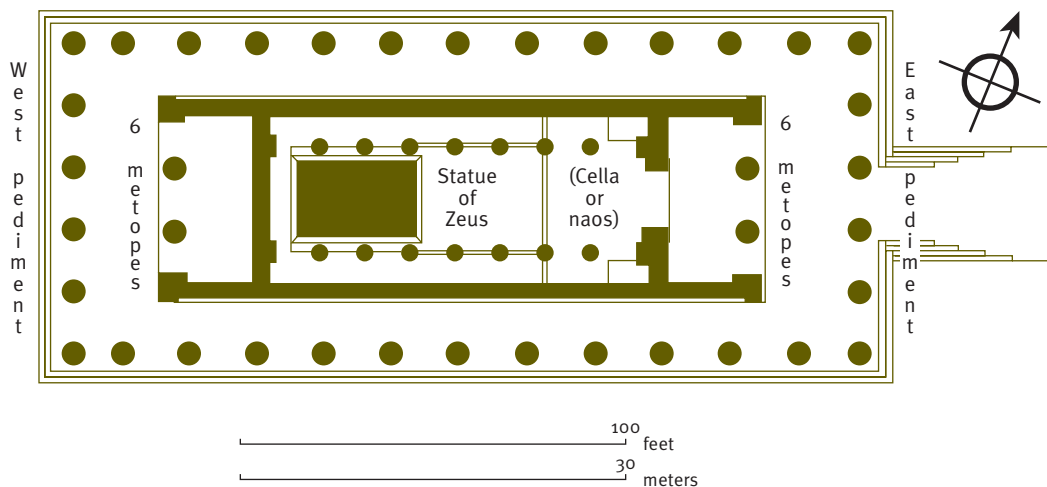


Figure 5.2. Plan of the Temple of Zeus at Olympia (after W. B. Dinsmoor)



Jupiter and Thetis. by J.-A.-D. Ingres (1780–1867); oil on canvas, 1811, 136 × 101 in. In this huge painting, Jupiter is enthroned among the clouds with his attributes, the scepter and the eagle. Thetis kneels and touches Jupiter's chin in a gesture of supplication. To the left, Juno (Hera) appears, though only partially, in a fairly relaxed pose, resting her head on her arms. This work in neoclassical style betrays two influences from antiquity: Homer and Pheidias' monumental, chryselephantine (gold and ivory) statue of Zeus at Olympia. In Book 1 of the *Iliad* Thetis approaches Zeus in the posture of a suppliant, grasping his knees and touching his chin, to request that Zeus aid her in restoring the honor of her son Achilles. The other influence, Pheidias' statue, has not survived, but Pausanias, the second-century A.D. travel writer, in his *Description of Greece* records in some detail the composition of the sculpture. Ingres has inverted the pose of the statue of Zeus at Olympia; in the ancient sculpture, Zeus, sitting upon his throne, grasps in his *left* hand the scepter with an eagle perched atop and in his *right* he holds the figure of Nike (Victory). According to Pausanias, the throne and pedestal were covered with elaborate decoration that Ingres has reduced to a simple relief of the Gigantomachy at the base of the pedestal. (Erich Lessing/*Art Resource*, NY)

Thus, in the temple and its statue, at the heart of the greatest of Panhellenic sanctuaries, myths of human and divine struggle and victory, of destruction and creation, combined to honor Zeus as the supreme god of civilization.¹⁰

The Oracles at Olympia and Dodona

Dodona (in northern Greece) as well as Olympia was an important center for the worship of Zeus, and both were frequented in antiquity for their oracular responses.

The traditional methods for eliciting a response from the god were by the observation and interpretation of omens, for example, the rustling of leaves, the

Oracles and Prophets

The famous oracles of Zeus at Olympia and Dodona and that of Apollo at Delphi were not the only sources of prophecy in ancient Greece. Here are some others.

The oracle of **Trophonius** was situated at Lebadeia in northern Boeotia. Trophonius is a chthonic hero (his name means “he who fosters growth”), and he was therefore consulted in a subterranean setting with an awesome ritual. His legend is similar to the story of the Egyptian pharaoh Rhampsinitus (Rameses), which Herodotus tells (2. 121). Trophonius and his brother Agamedes were skilled builders, sons of Erginus of Orchomenus. They built for King Augeas of Elis (or, as some say, the Boeotian king Hyrieus) a treasury with a movable stone, which they used to steal the king’s treasure. In time, the king set a trap for the unknown thief, and Agamedes was caught. At his own suggestion, Agamedes’ head was cut off by Trophonius, who then escaped carrying the head. He fled to Lebadeia, where he was swallowed up by the earth and thereafter worshiped as a god.¹¹ His death is similar to that of **Amphiaraüs**, one of the Seven against Thebes, whose story is told on p. 428.

Melampus was a seer with the power of understanding the speech of animals. He had honored a pair of snakes killed by his servants by burning their bodies and rearing their young, who later licked his ears and so enabled him to understand the tongues of animals and birds, and from them know what was going to happen. For the story of Melampus and his brother Bias, see p. 561.

The priest and seer Tiresias is a prominent figure in the Theban saga (see pp. 432–434). For **the role of historical seers in Greek religion**, see pp. 156–157.

sound of the wind in the branches of his sacred oaks, the call of doves, and the condition of burnt offerings. At Olympia, inquiries were usually confined to the chances of the competitors in the games. Eventually at Dodona, through the influence of the oracle of Apollo at Delphi, a priestess would mount a tripod and deliver her communications from the god.¹² Here leaden tablets have been found inscribed with all kinds of questions posed by the state and the individual. The people of Corcyra ask Zeus to what god or hero they should pray or sacrifice for their common good; others ask if it is safe to join a federation; a man inquires if it is good for him to marry; another, whether he will have children from his wife. There are questions about purchases, health, and family.

Herodotus (2.55) visited Dodona and was told by three priestesses why the oracle of Zeus was founded; their story was confirmed as true by other servants of the temple. The priestesses’ names were Promeneia, the eldest; Timarete, next in age; and Nicandra, the youngest. Two black doves flew from Thebes in Egypt; one came to Libya and the other to Dodona. The latter settled on an oak tree and spoke in human speech, saying that an oracle of Zeus must be established there. The people of Dodona understood that the message was divine and so obeyed the command. The dove that came to Libya ordered the Libyans to establish an oracle there, to the Egyptian god Ammon and also sacred to Zeus.

Children of Zeus and Hera: Eileithyia, Hebe, Hephaestus, and Ares

Eileithyia, Goddess of Childbirth

Zeus and Hera have four children: Eileithyia, Hebe, Hephaestus, and Ares. Eileithyia is a goddess of childbirth, a role she shares with her mother Hera; at times mother and daughter merge in identity. Artemis (as we shall see in Chapter 10) is another important goddess of childbirth.

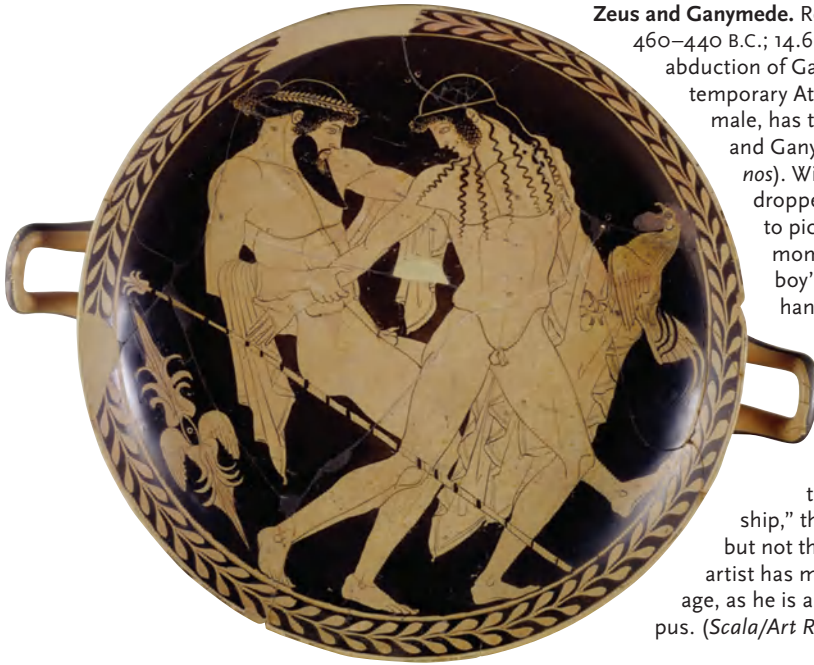
Hebe and Ganymede, Cupbearers to the Gods

Hebe is the goddess of youthful bloom (the literal meaning of her name). She is a servant of the gods as well.¹³ Hebe is primarily known as the cupbearer for the deities on Olympus. When Heracles wins immortality, she becomes his bride. Some versions explain that she resigned from her position to marry. Late authors claim that she was discharged for clumsiness.

Interpretations of the Myth of Ganymede

This story indeed illustrates succinctly and powerfully the wide variation of interpretation and reinterpretation that all myths are capable of inspiring—a principal reason for their immortality. The *Homeric Hymn to Aphrodite* tells a simple and beautiful story of how wise Zeus singled out handsome Ganymede to grace Olympus as cupbearer and live there forever, immortal, like a god. Its ecstatic spirituality emerges with sublimity in the poem “Ganymede” by Goethe (especially in its musical settings by Schubert and Wolf). The incident is seen from the point of view of a devoted Ganymede. In a passionate yet spiritual aura, amidst the glowing sun, beloved spring, and burning love, Ganymede ecstatically cries to the descending clouds to carry him aloft: “In your lap, upwards, embracing, embraced. Upwards to your breast, loving father.” For a different artist, the homosexuality latent in the myth may offer amoral or nonmoral testimony to the fact of a physical relationship, and not a religious calling. Another may tell the story to prove a divine vindication of male relationships. Yet another may vehemently identify the myth as a horrifying Rape of Ganymede by Zeus—accusing God of this brutal sin, an idea inconceivable to the poet and philosopher Xenophanes (see p. 139). The tale may even become (as in the case of the Greek writer Lucian, *Dialogues of the Gods* 4 [10 in the Loeb edition]) a divinely amusing, urbane, satiric jest. So is this a myth about a religious experience, a summoning by God to heaven, a rape, or is it merely a joke? It depends on how the story is told and how it is interpreted; many are the possible variations. There is, of course, no single “correct” interpretation of a great myth. Myth is protean by nature, most gratifying because it forever changes through the personality and genius of each and every artist, in any medium at any time, to provide pleasure and enlightenment in our search for our own individual meaning and enrichment in the work of art.

The myth of Zeus and Ganymede is similar to the story of how Poseidon fell in love with Pelops and brought him up to Olympus (see p. 438).



Zeus and Ganymede. Red-figure kylix, by the Penthesilea painter, ca. 460–440 B.C.; 14.6 in. in diameter. On this vase, the myth of the abduction of Ganymede by Zeus is interpreted in the light of contemporary Athenian sexual mores. Zeus, the mature bearded male, has taken on the role of the active “lover” (*erastes*) and Ganymede that of the passive “beloved” (*eromenos*). With his stylized thunderbolt put by, Zeus, having dropped his scepter, which Ganymede is intently trying to pick up, takes advantage of the young man’s momentary distraction to grab hold of the boy’s right arm. Ganymede holds a cockerel in his left hand, a typical gift of courtship from an older lover. The kylix is a shallow drinking cup typically used for wine, and so inevitably also at all-male symposia or drinking parties, where such “conquests” might be celebrated, although this vase and its theme need not be linked to any specific occasion. The narrative of the vase highlights the beginning of the “courtship,” the moment that Eros has struck the older male but not the younger. In a particularly playful rendering, the artist has made Zeus use the contours of the vase for leverage, as he is about to begin their ascent to the heights of Olympus. (Scala/Art Resource, NY)

The Trojan prince Ganymede shares honors with Hebe as cupbearer of the gods; according to some authors, he replaces her. The *Homeric Hymn to Aphrodite* (5. 202–217), translated in its entirety in Chapter 9, tells how Zeus carried off Ganymede, the handsome son of Tros:

Indeed, Zeus in his wisdom seized and carried off fair-haired Ganymede because of his beauty, so that he might be in the company of the gods and pour wine for them in the house of Zeus, a wonder to behold, esteemed by all the immortals, as he draws the red nectar from a golden bowl. But a lasting sorrow gripped the heart of Tros, for he had no idea where the divine whirlwind had taken his dear son. Indeed he mourned for him unceasingly each and every day; and Zeus took pity on the father and gave him, as recompense for his son, brisk-trotting horses, the kind which carry the gods. These he gave him to have as a gift. (202–212)

And at the command of Zeus, Hermes, the guide and slayer of Argus, told everything and how Ganymede would be immortal and never grow old, just like the gods. When Tros heard this message from Zeus, he no longer continued his mourning but rejoiced within his heart and joyfully was borne by the horses that were as swift as a storm. (212–217)

In some accounts an eagle, not a whirlwind, carries Ganymede away. For some, this myth represents the spiritual calling of a young man by god; others attribute homosexual desire to a bisexual Zeus, thus having the supreme god mirror yet another human trait.¹⁴

Hephaestus, the Divine Artisan

Hephaestus, the next child of Zeus and Hera to be considered, is a god of creative fire and a divine smith. His divine workshop is often placed in heaven or on Olympus. All that this immortal craftsman produces excites wonder; his

major role in mythology is to create things of extraordinary beauty and utility, often elaborately wrought. One of his masterpieces, the shield of Achilles, is described in exquisite detail by Homer (*Iliad* 18. 468–617). Hephaestus even has attendants fashioned of gold that look like living young women; these robots can move with intelligence and speak with knowledge. He is indeed the master artisan. Sometimes his forge is under the earth; and as he labors covered with soot and sweat, he may be attended by the three Cyclopes, whom we already know as the ones who create the thunder and lightning of Zeus.¹⁵

Hephaestus is also a god of fire in general, including destructive fire. When the Scamander (both a river and its god) is about to engulf the hero Achilles during an episode in the Trojan War (*Iliad* 21. 324–382), Hera calls upon Hephaestus to raise up his fire and direct it against the raging river, which soon is overcome by the flames.¹⁶

Hephaestus and the goddess Athena were often linked together as benefactors of wisdom in the arts and crafts and champions of progress and civilization. Their joint worship was particularly significant in Athens. In the *Homeric Hymn to Hephaestus* (20), they are invoked together as archetypal, divine culture figures like Prometheus.

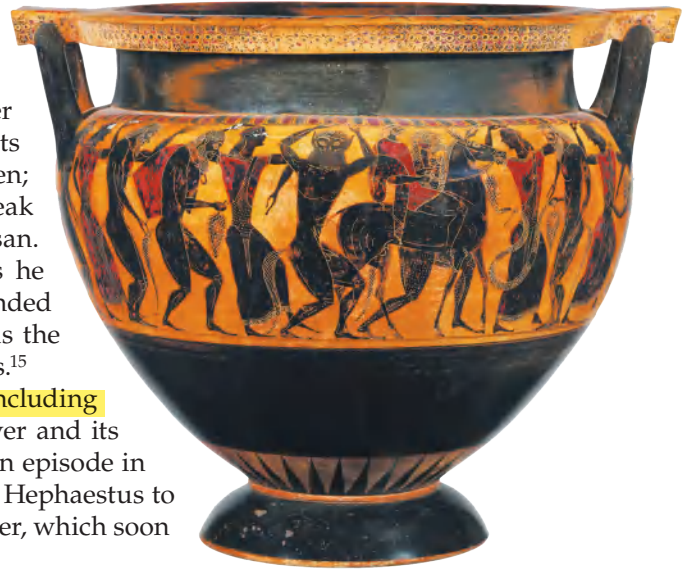
Sing, clear-voiced Muse, about Hephaestus, renowned for his intelligence, who, with bright-eyed Athena, taught splendid arts to human beings on earth. Previously they used to live in mountain caves, like animals, but now, because of Hephaestus, renowned for his skill, they have learned his crafts and live year round with ease and comfort in their own houses.

Be kind, Hephaestus, and give me both excellence and prosperity.

The god Hephaestus was lame from birth. One version of his birth informs us that Hera claimed that Hephaestus was her son alone without Zeus; thus, Hera has her own favorite child, born from herself, just as Zeus has his special daughter, Athena, who was born from his head. In this version too, Hera was ashamed of his deformity and cast him down from Olympus or heaven.¹⁷ Hephaestus refused to listen to any of the other gods, who urged that he return home, except for Dionysus in whom he had the greatest trust. Dionysus made him drunk and brought him back to Olympus triumphantly. On vases this scene is variously depicted with a tipsy Hephaestus on foot or astride a donkey, led by Dionysus alone or with his retinue.

We are also told that Hephaestus was hurled to earth (presumably on another occasion?), this time by Zeus. Hephaestus landed on the island of Lemnos, was rescued, and eventually returned home. Lemnos in classical times was an important center of his worship. Other volcanic regions (e.g., Sicily and its environs) were also associated with this divine smith; these places bore testimony to the fire and smoke that at times would erupt from his forge.

At the close of Book 1 of the *Iliad*, Hephaestus himself recounts the episode of Zeus' anger against him. We excerpt this passage because it illustrates many things: the character of Hephaestus; his closeness to his mother, Hera; the tone and atmosphere instigated by an episode in the life of the Olympian



Hephaestus' Return to Olympus. Attic black-figure krater by Lydos, ca. 550 B.C.; height 2 ft. The painter has placed Hephaestus, who is drunk, on a mule, while Dionysus appears on the other side of the vase (not shown). Hephaestus is accompanied by a *thiasos*, an entourage of satyrs and maenads, some of whom hold snakes or clusters of grapes. The satyrs have tails, particularly splendid on the satyr immediately to the left of the mule. (Image copyright © The Metropolitan Museum of Art. Image source: Art Resource, NY / © Artres)

The Finding of Vulcan on the Island of Lemnos, by Piero di Cosimo (1462–1522), painted in about 1400; 61 × 68 ¾ in. In *Iliad* 1. 590–594 (translated on p. 127), Hephaestus recalls how he was thrown out of Olympus by Zeus and fell all day, landing on Lemnos in the evening. Piero records the event, portraying Hephaestus as a boy, while the hole in the clouds, through which he was thrown from the sky, is seen in the upper left center. He is rescued by six Sintian women, whose tender attentions and peaceful activities contrast with the anger and violence of Zeus. (Wadsworth Atheneum Museum of Art/Art Resource, NY)



Closer Look



family; Zeus as the stern father in his house and his difficult relations with his wife; and the uneasy emotions of the children while they witness the quarrel of their parents.

The sea-goddess Thetis has come to Zeus on Olympus to ask that he grant victory to the Trojans until the Achaean Greeks honor her son Achilles and give him recompense for the insult that he has suffered. As Thetis clasps the knees of Zeus and touches his chin in the traditional posture of a suppliant, Zeus agrees to her wishes with these words (*Iliad* 1. 518–611):



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“A bad business indeed if you set me at variance with Hera and she reviles me with reproaches. She always abuses me, even as it is, in the presence of the immortal gods and says that I help the Trojans in battle. But you now must withdraw, lest Hera notice anything. These things you have asked for will be my concern until I accomplish them. Come now, I shall nod my assent to you so that you may be convinced. For this from me is the greatest pledge among the immortals; for no promise of mine is revocable or false or unfulfilled to which I give assent with the nod of my head.” He spoke and the son of Cronus with his dark brows nodded to her wishes; and the ambrosial locks flowed round the immortal head of the lord and he made great Olympus tremble.¹⁸ (518–530)

After the two had made their plans, they parted; then she leaped into the deep sea from shining Olympus and Zeus returned to his own house. All the gods rose together from their places in the presence of their father and no one dared to

remain seated as he entered but all stood before him. Thereupon he sat down on his throne. But Hera did not fail to observe that silver-footed Thetis, daughter of the old man of the sea, had taken counsel with him. Immediately she addressed Zeus, the son of Cronus, with cutting remarks: "Which one of the gods this time has taken counsel with you, crafty rogue? Always it is dear to you to think secret thoughts and to make decisions apart from me and never yet have you dared say 20 a word openly to me about what you are thinking." (531–543)

Then the father of men and gods answered her: "Hera, do not hope to know all that I say; it would be difficult for you even though you are my wife. But whatever is fitting that you should hear, then not anyone either of gods nor of mortals will know it before you. But do not pry or ask questions about each and every thing to which I wish to give thought apart from the gods." (544–550)

And then ox-eyed Hera in her majesty replied: "Most dread son of Cronus, what kind of answer is this you have given? I have not pried too much or asked questions before but completely on your own you plan whatever you wish. Yet now I am terribly afraid in my heart that silver-footed Thetis, daughter of the old 30 man of the sea, has won you over; for early this morning she sat by your side and grasped your knees and I believe that you nodded your oath that you would honor Achilles and destroy many by the ships of the Achaeans." (551–559)

The cloud-gatherer Zeus spoke to her in answer: "You always believe some thing and I never escape you; nevertheless you will be able to accomplish nothing, but you will be farther removed from my heart; and this will be all the more chill an experience for you. If what you say is so, its fulfillment is what I desire. But sit down in silence, and obey what I say; for now all the gods in Olympus will be of no avail when I come closer and lay my invincible hands upon you." 40 Thus he spoke and ox-eyed lady Hera was afraid, and she sat down in silence wrenching her heart to obedience, and the gods of heaven were troubled in the house of Zeus. (560–570)

But Hephaestus renowned for his art began to make a speech to them showing his concern for his dear mother, Hera of the white arms. "This will be a sorry business indeed and not to be endured any longer, if you two quarrel on account of mortals and bring wrangling among the gods. There will be no further pleasure in the excellent feast when baser instincts prevail. I advise my mother, even though she is prudent, to act kindly toward my dear father Zeus so that he will not be abusive again and disturb our banquet. Just suppose he, the Olympian 50 hurler of lightning, wishes to blast us from our seats. For he is by far the strongest. But you touch him with gentle words; immediately then the Olympian will be kindly toward us." (571–583)

Thus he spoke and springing up he placed a cup with two handles in the hand of his mother and spoke to her: "Bear up, mother dear, and endure, although you are hurt, so that I may not see you struck before my eyes, and then even though you are dear and I am distressed I shall not be able to help. For the Olympian is hard to oppose. Previously on another occasion when I was eager to defend you, he grabbed me by the feet and hurled me from the divine threshold. And I fell the whole day and landed on Lemnos when the sun was setting, and little life was left in me. There Sintian men took care of me at once 60 after my fall." (584–594)

Thus he spoke. And the goddess Hera of the white arms smiled and as she smiled she received the cup from his hand. He drew sweet nectar from a mixing bowl and poured it like wine for all the other gods from left to right. Then

The Forge of Vulcan, by Diego Velázquez (1599–1660); oil on canvas, 1630; 88 in. × 114 in. Velázquez has painted the moment when Helios tells Hephaestus that his wife, Aphrodite, is making love to Ares (Homer, *Odyssey* 8. 270–271). At the appearance of Helios in the forge, Hephaestus and his four assistants stop their work on a suit of armor (perhaps for Ares himself), stunned by the news. Helios, whose white flesh, blue-thonged sandals, and orange robe contrast with the burly torsos of the blacksmiths, is both sun-god and Apollo, god of poetry (as his laurel wreath indicates). The rays from his head illuminate the dark forge, while the exquisite white jug on the mantelpiece provides another focus of light on the opposite side of the painting. Velázquez catches the intersection of divine omniscience and the blacksmith's toil without diminishing the wit and pathos of Homer's tale. The great anvil in the left foreground, we know, waits for Hephaestus to forge on it the inescapable metal net that will trap the lovers. (*Scala/Art Resource*, NY)



unquenchable laughter rose up among the blessed gods as they saw Hephaestus bustling about the house. (595–600)

In this way then the whole day until the sun went down they feasted, nor was anyone's desire for his share of the banquet found wanting nor of the exquisite lyre that Apollo held nor of the Muses, who sang in harmony with beautiful voice. But when the bright light of the sun set they went to bed each to his own home which the renowned lame god Hephaestus had built by his skill and knowledge. Olympian Zeus, the hurler of lightning, went to his own bed where he always lay down until sweet sleep would come to him. There he went and took his rest and beside him was Hera of the golden throne. (601–611)

Hephaestus, Aphrodite, and Ares

Hephaestus is a figure of amusement as he hobbles around acting as the cup-bearer to the gods in the previous scene, on Olympus; but he is a deadly serious figure in his art and in his love. His wife is Aphrodite,¹⁹ and theirs is a strange and tempestuous marriage: the union of beauty and deformity, the intellectual and the sensual. Aphrodite is unfaithful to her husband and turns to the virile Ares, handsome and whole, brutal and strong. Homer, with deceptive simplicity, lays bare the psychological implications in a tale about the eternal triangle that remains forever fresh in its humanity and insights.

In Book 8 (266–366) of the *Odyssey*, the bard Demodocus sings of the love affair between Ares and Aphrodite and the suffering of Hephaestus:

He took up the lyre and began to sing beautifully of the love of Ares and Aphrodite with the fair crown: how first they lay together by stealth in the home



Closer Look



Audio

of Hephaestus. He gave her many gifts and defiled the marriage bed of lord Hephaestus. But soon Helios, the Sun, came to him as a messenger, for he saw them in the embrace of love, and Hephaestus when he heard the painful tale went straight to his forge planning evil in his heart. He put his great anvil on its stand and hammered out chains that could not be broken or loosened so that they would hold fast on the spot. (266–275)

When he had fashioned this cunning device in his rage against Ares, he went directly to his chamber where the bed was and spread the many shackles all around the bedposts and hung them suspended from the rafters, like a fine spider's web that no one could see, not even the blessed gods, for they were very cunningly made. When he had arranged the whole device all about the bed, he pretended to journey to the well-built citadel of Lemnos, which of all lands was by far the most dear to him. (276–284)

But Ares of the golden reins was not blind in his watch, and as he saw Hephaestus leave he went straight to the house of the craftsman renowned for his art, eager for love with Cytherea of the fair crown. She was sitting, having just come from her mighty father, the son of Cronus, when Ares came into the house; he took her hand and spoke out exclaiming: "My love, come let us go to bed and take our pleasure, for Hephaestus is no longer at home but he has gone now, probably to visit Lemnos and the Sintian inhabitants with their barbarous speech." Thus he spoke and to her the invitation seemed most gratifying; they both went and lay down on the bed. And the bonds fashioned by ingenious Hephaestus poured around them, and they were not able to raise or move a limb. Then to be sure they knew that there was no longer any escape. (285–299)

The renowned lame god came from close by; he had turned back before he had reached the land of Lemnos, for Helios watched from his lookout and told him the story. Hephaestus made for his home, grieving in his heart, and he stood in the doorway and wild rage seized him; he cried out in a loud and terrible voice to all the gods: "Father Zeus and you other blessed gods who live forever, come here so that you may see something that is laughable and cruel: how Aphrodite the daughter of Zeus always holds me in contempt since I am lame and loves the butcher Ares because he is handsome and sound of limb, but I was born a cripple. I am not to blame for this nor is anyone else except both my parents who I wish had never begotten me. You will see how these two went into my bed where they lay down together in love. As I look at them I am overcome by anguish. I do not think that they will still want to lie here in this way for even a brief time, although they are so very much in love, and very quickly they will no longer wish to sleep side by side, for my cunning and my bonds will hold them fast until her father pays back all the gifts that I gave to him for this hussy because she was his daughter and beautiful, but she is wanton in her passion." (300–320)

Thus he spoke and the gods assembled at his house with the floor of bronze. Poseidon the earthshaker came and Hermes the helpful runner, and lord Apollo the far-shooter. But the goddesses in their modesty stayed at home one and all. The blessed gods, dispensers of good things, stood at the door and unquenchable laughter rose up among them as they saw the skill of ingenious Hephaestus. And one would speak to another who was next to him as follows: "Bad deeds do not prosper; the slow overtakes the swift, since now Hephaestus who is slow and lame has caught by his skill Ares, even though he is the swiftest of the gods who inhabit Olympus. Therefore he must pay the penalty for being caught in adultery." This was the sort of thing that they said to one another. (321–333)

And lord Apollo, son of Zeus, spoke to Hermes: “Hermes, son of Zeus, runner and bestower of blessings, would you wish to lie in bed by the side of golden Aphrodite, even though pressed in by mighty shackles?” Then the swift runner Hermes answered: “I only wish it were so, lord Apollo, far-shooter. Let there be three times the number of shackles and you gods looking on and all the goddesses, I still would lie by the side of golden Aphrodite.” (334–342)

Thus he spoke and a laugh rose up among the immortal gods. But Poseidon did not laugh; he relentlessly begged Hephaestus, the renowned smith, to release Ares and addressed him with winged words: “Release him. I promise you that he will pay all that is fitting in the presence of the immortal gods, as you demand.” Then the renowned lame god answered: “Do not demand this of me, Poseidon, earthshaker; pledges made on behalf of worthless characters are worthless to have and to keep. How could I hold you fast in the presence of the immortal gods, if Ares gets away and escapes both his debt and his chains?” Then Poseidon the earthshaker answered: “Hephaestus, if Ares avoids his debt and escapes and flees, I myself will pay up.” Then the renowned lame god replied: “I cannot and I must not deny your request.” (343–358)

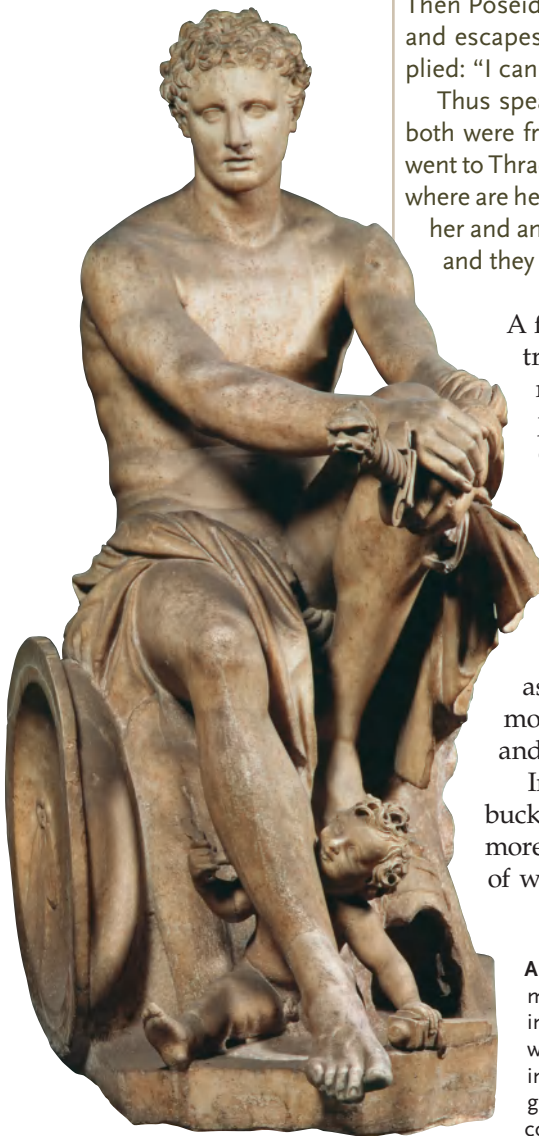
Thus speaking, Hephaestus in his might released the chains. And when they both were freed from the strong bonds, they immediately darted away, the one went to Thrace and the other, laughter-loving Aphrodite, came to Paphos in Cyprus where are her sanctuary and altar fragrant with sacrifices. There the Graces bathed her and anointed her with divine oil, the kind that is used by the immortal gods, and they clothed her in lovely garments, a wonder to behold. (359–366)

A funny, yet painful story, glib in its sophisticated and ironic portrayal of the gods, but permeated with a deep and unshakable moral judgment and conviction. The Greeks particularly enjoyed the fact that the lame Hephaestus, by his intelligence and craft, outwits the nimble and powerful Ares.

Ares, God of War

Ares himself, the god of war, is the last child of Zeus and Hera to be considered. His origins probably belong to Thrace, an area with which he is often linked. Aphrodite is usually named as his cult partner; several children are attributed to them, the most important being Eros. Dawn (Eos) was one of his mistresses, and we have already mentioned (in Chapter 3) Aphrodite’s jealousy.

In character, Ares is generally depicted as a kind of divine swash-buckler. He is not highly thought of, and at times he appears as little more than a butcher. The more profound moral and theological aspects of war were taken over by other deities, especially Zeus or Athena.



Ares. Roman copy of a Greek original (possibly by Skopas) of ca. 340 B.C.; marble, height 61-½ in. Known as the *Ludovisi Mars*, this copy (made perhaps in the late second century A.D.) shows Mars, unarmed but holding his sword, with the scabbard-handle turned toward the viewer and with his left foot resting on his helmet. His shield is upright (the inside face turned outward). Is the god simply at rest, or has he been subdued by love, as the Cupid (added by the copyist) implies? (*Scala/Art Resource, NY*)

Zeus' response to Ares after he has been wounded by Diomedes (Ares sometimes gets the worst of things, even in battle) is typical of the Greek attitude toward him (*Iliad* 5. 889–891, 895–898).

Do not sit beside me and complain, you two-faced rogue. Of all the gods who dwell on Olympus you are the most hateful to me, for strife and wars and battles are always dear to you. . . . Still I shall not endure any longer that you be in pain, for you are of my blood and your mother bore you to me. But if you were born of some other of the gods, since you are so destructive you would have long since been thrown out of Olympus.

The Greeks felt strongly about the brutality, waste, and folly of war, all of which are personified and deified in the figure of Ares. Yet they inevitably developed an appreciation (if that is the right word) of the harsh realities that Ares could impose and the various aspects of warfare that he might represent. After all, throughout much of their history the Greeks (like us) were plagued by war; and in the pages of the great historian Thucydides we see most clearly of all that despicable war is the harshest of teachers. The Greeks *did* worship Ares, Athena, and Zeus as divine champions in righteous conflict.

The *Homeric Hymn to Ares* (8), a relatively late composition with its astrological reference to the planet Ares (Mars), invokes with more compassion a god of greater complexity who is to provide an intelligent and controlled courage.²⁰

Ares—superior in force, chariot-rider, golden-helmeted, shield-bearer, stalwart in battle, savior of cities, bronze-armored, strong-fisted, unwearyingly relentless, mighty with the spear, defense of Olympus, father of the war-champion Nike [Victory], ally of Themis [Right], tyrant against the rebellious, champion for the righteous, sceptered king of manhood—as you whirl your fiery red sphere among the planets in their seven courses through the air, where your blazing steeds keep you forever above the third orbit,²¹ hear me, helper of mortals, giver of vigorous youth; from above shed upon my life a martial ferocity, so that I may be able to drive off bitter cowardice from my person, and then again a radiant gentleness so that I may be able to bend to my will the treacherous impulse of my spirit to rush to the attack and check the keen fury of my passion which drives me to engage in the chilling din of battle. (1–15)

You, blessed one, give me the strength to keep within the harmless constraints of peace and flee from the strife of enemies and violence of fateful death. (15–17)

Other Children of Zeus: The Muses and the Fates

The Nine Muses, Daughters of Zeus and Memory (Mnemosyne)

We shall conclude this chapter with two of Zeus' many affairs because of the universal significance of the offspring. He mates with the Titaness Mnemosyne (Memory), and she gives birth to the Muses, the patronesses of literature and the arts; thus allegorically Memory with divine help produces inspiration. The home of the Muses is often located in Pieria in northern Thessaly near Mt. Olympus,²²

or about the fountain Hippocrene on Mt. Helicon in Boeotia. The Muses (their name means “the reminders”) may originally have been water spirits with the power of prophecy and then inspiration, imagined from the babbling of waters as they flow. They are supreme in their fields, and those who dare to challenge them meet with defeat and punishment. In this respect they resemble Apollo, with whom they are often associated. The number of the Muses is not consistent, but later authors usually identify nine of them, each with a specific function, although assignments will vary. Calliope presides over epic poetry; Clio, history (or lyre playing); Euterpe, lyric poetry (or tragedy and flute playing); Melpomene, tragedy (or lyre playing); Terpsichore, choral dancing (or flute playing); Erato, love poetry (or hymns to the gods and lyre playing); Polyhymnia, sacred music (or dancing); Urania, astronomy; and Thalia, comedy.

In the *Homeric Hymn to the Muses and Apollo* (25), the great deity Apollo is invoked along with them because as god of music, poetry, and the arts he is often their associate.

With the Muses, let me begin, and with Apollo and Zeus. For through the Muses and far-shooting Apollo, human beings on earth are poets and musicians; but through Zeus, they are kings. Blessed are the ones whom the Muses love; sweet is the sound that flows from their lips. (1–5)

Hail, children of Zeus, and give honor to my song; yet I shall remember you and another song too. (6–7)

The Three Fates, Daughters of Zeus and Themis

Zeus is sometimes said to be the father of the Fates (Greek, *Moirai*; *Parcae* for the Romans) as a result of his union with Themis. Night and Erebus are also said to be their parents. The Fates were originally birth spirits who often came to be depicted as three old women responsible for the destiny of every individual. Clotho (Spinner) spins out the thread of life, which carries with it the fate of each human being from the moment of birth; Lachesis (Apportioner) measures the thread; and Atropos (Inflexible), sometimes characterized as the smallest and most terrible, cuts it off and brings life to an end. On occasion, they can be influenced to alter the fate decreed by their labors, but usually the course of the destiny that they spin is irrevocable.

Fate is often thought of in the singular (Greek, *Moirai*), in a conception that is much more abstract and more closely linked to a profound realization of the roles played by Luck or Fortune (Tyche) and Necessity (Ananke) in the scheme of human life. The relation of the gods to destiny is variously depicted and intriguing to analyze in the literature. According to some authors, Zeus is supreme and controls all, but others portray a universe in which even the great and powerful Zeus must bow to the inevitability of Fate’s decrees. The depth of the Greeks’ feeling for the working of *Moirai* or the *Moirai* cannot be overemphasized. It provides a definite and unique tone and color to the bulk of their writing. One thinks immediately of Homer or Herodotus or the tragedians, but no major author was untouched by fascination with the interrelation of god, mortals, and fate and the tantalizing interplay of destiny and free will.²³

In the brief *Homeric Hymn to the Supreme Son of Cronus* (23), Zeus is invoked as the intimate confidant of Themis; for Zeus and Themis were the parents not only of the Fates but also of the Hours (Horae)²⁴ and (appropriately for this hymn) of Good Order (Eunomia), Justice (Dike), and Peace (Eirene).

About Zeus, I will sing, the best and greatest of the gods, far-seeing ruler and accomplisher, who confides his words of wisdom to Themis, as she sits and leans close. Be kind, far-seeing son of Cronus, most glorious and most great.

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Homeric Hymn 8	<i>To Ares</i>
Homeric Hymn 12	<i>To Hera</i>
Homeric Hymn 20	<i>To Hephaestus</i>
Homeric Hymn 23	<i>To the Supreme Son of Cronus</i>
Homeric Hymn 24	<i>To Hestia</i>
Homeric Hymn 25	<i>To the Muses and Apollo</i>
Homeric Hymn 29	<i>To Hestia</i>
Homer	<i>Iliad</i> 1.518–611; 5.889–891, 895–898
Homer	<i>Odyssey</i> 8.216–366

Additional Sources

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Pausanias	<i>Description of Greece</i> 5.7.6–5.9.6: History of Olympia and the games

Notes

1. The Roman gods are discussed on pp. 667–684.
2. See the lines (21–32) about Hestia in the *Homeric Hymn to Aphrodite*, translated in Chapter 9, p. 203. Sometimes Hestia does not seem to be conceived fully as an anthropomorphic deity.
3. Pytho is Delphi, the site of Apollo’s great temple; oil was used as an ointment for hair, and in religious rites it was poured over the heads of statues.
4. The warrior-goddess Athena will also carry the aegis, on which may be depicted the head of the Gorgon Medusa whom she helped Perseus slay. Athena’s aegis may be her own or lent by Zeus to his favorite daughter.
5. Zeus and Hera find their archetypal counterparts in the Wotan and Fricka of Nordic mythology.
6. These games were celebrated every four years after 776; an important system of dating for the Greeks was by Olympiads.
7. Long before 776 B.C., the pre-Olympian deities Cronus and Gaia were worshiped at Olympia. For Heracles at Olympia, see pp. 559, 562–563.
8. The temple was completed in 456 B.C.; the statue, ca. 430 B.C.
9. It was described in detail by the traveler Pausanias (5. 11) in the second century A.D.; the Roman Quintilian wrote, “its beauty added something even to the traditional religion.”
10. See Bernard Ashmole, N. Yalouris, and Alison Franz, *Olympia: The Sculptures of the Temple of Zeus* (New York: Phaidon, 1967); John Boardman, *Greek Sculpture: The Classical Period* (London: Thames and Hudson, 1985), Chapter 4, “Olympia: The Temple of Zeus,” pp. 33–50, includes diagrams, reconstructions, and photographs to illustrate the very brief discussion; Martin Robertson, *A Shorter History of Greek Art* (New York: Cambridge University Press, 1981) (pp. 79–89 for the sculptures of the temple of Zeus at Olympia), is by far the best discussion, distilled from the author’s *A History of Greek Art*, 2 vols. (1975), pp. 271–291.
11. Pindar (frags. 2–3), however, has a different story of the brothers’ death, one very similar to Herodotus’ story of the Argives Cleobis and Biton (see p. 144). In this version, Trophonius and Agamedes built the temple of Apollo at Delphi. When they asked the god for their wages, he said he would pay them on the seventh day. On that day they fell asleep, never to wake. In the *Homeric Hymn to Apollo* (see p. 255) the god himself lays the foundations of the temple.
12. Olympia was not as famous for its oracles as was the sanctuary of Apollo at Delphi, another famous Panhellenic festival (i.e., one to which “all Hellenes” came). Delphi was similar to Olympia and is described in Chapter 11 in some detail as representative of this facet of Hellenic worship and life (see pp. 252–255).
13. In the *Iliad* (5. 905), Hebe bathes and clothes Ares after he has been healed of the wounds inflicted by the hero Diomedes.
14. For the theme of homosexuality, see Chapter 1, pp. 22–23.
15. Homer (*Iliad* 18) presents a splendid picture of his house on Olympus when Thetis appeals to Hephaestus to forge new armor for her son Achilles. Vergil (*Aeneid* 8) locates Vulcan’s workshop in a cave on the island of Vulcania near Sicily. There he fashions magnificent armor for Aeneas, the son of Venus.
16. This scene is not unlike the finale of Act 3 of Richard Wagner’s *Die Walküre*, in which Wotan conjures up Loge to surround his Valkyrie daughter Brünnhilde with a ring of magic fire.
17. For this version, see the *Homeric Hymn to Apollo* in the Additional Reading to Chapter 11.

18. Pheidias' majestic statue of the seated figure of Zeus in the temple at Olympia (described earlier) was supposedly inspired by these lines from Homer describing Zeus as he nods.
19. Sometimes Hephaestus' mate is one of the Graces, either the youngest, Aglaea, or Grace herself (Charis), which actually may be but another designation for Aphrodite.
20. This hymn probably belongs to Hellenistic times or even later; some, not very convincingly, associate it with the corpus of Orphic hymns. The richer connotations given to Ares' character and the emphasis on strength in peace as well as war look to Mars, the Roman counterpart of Ares; see pp. 670–671.
21. Ares is in the third planetary zone, if you count from the one that is farthest from Earth.
22. The Muses are sometimes called the Pierides, but Ovid (*Metamorphoses* 5. 205–678) tells a story of nine daughters of Pierus of Pella in Macedonia who were also called Pierides. They challenged the Muses to a musical contest, lost, and were changed into magpies, birds that imitate sounds and chatter incessantly.
23. The Romans developed this same tragic view of human existence. For them Fate is personified by the Parcae, or more abstractly conceived as Fatum (Fate).
24. The Horae, Hours, become the Seasons, goddesses who are two, three, or four in number and closely connected with vegetation. They attend the greater deities and provide attractive decoration in literature and art. Zeus and Themis as sky-god and earth-goddess, respectively, enact once again the ritual of the sacred marriage.



The Nature of the Gods and Greek Religion

This only is denied to God: the power to undo the past.

—ARISTOTLE,

Nicomachean Ethics 6.2.4 (quoting the playwright Agathon)

Anthropomorphism

By now the nature of the anthropomorphic conception of deity that evolved among the Greeks and the Romans should be evident. The gods are generally depicted as human in form and character; but although they look and act like humans, very often their appearance and their actions are to some extent idealized. Their beauty is beyond that of ordinary mortals, their passions are more grand and intense, their sentiments more praiseworthy and touching; and they can embody and impose the loftiest moral values in the universe. Yet these same gods can mirror the physical and spiritual weaknesses of human counterparts: they can be lame and deformed or vain, petty, and insincere; they can steal, lie, and cheat, sometimes with a finesse that is exquisitely divine.

The gods usually live in houses on Mt. Olympus or in heaven; a very important distinction, however, is to be made between those deities of the upper air and the upper world (the Olympians) and those of the realm below, appropriately named **chthonian** (i.e., of the earth). They eat and drink, but their food is **ambrosia** and their wine **nectar**. **Ichor** (a substance clearer than blood) flows in their veins. Just as they can feel the gamut of human emotion, so too they can suffer physical pain and